Deep Research Report

The Oily Black Stone in A Song of Ice and Fire

July 8, 2026

Source lanes: Primary Canon | Authorial Statements | Fan Analysis | Literary Influences
51 unique sources | 20 cross-referenced claims | 4 parallel research agents
All book quotes verified verbatim against the full-text corpus index

Executive Summary

The "black, oily stone" is one of the most deliberately constructed background mysteries in George R.R. Martin's world, and the evidence supports five headline conclusions.

First, the mystery is smaller in the novels than fans remember. The exact phrase "oily black stone" appears exactly once in the five published novels: Theon's description of the Seastone Chair in A Clash of Kings. Every other oily-stone site (Asshai, Yeen, the Toad Stone, the Battle Isle fortress) exists only in The World of Ice and Fire, filtered through Maester Yandel, an in-world narrator who hedges constantly and twice goes out of his way to dismiss black-stone theories. That structure is itself evidence: Martin confirmed in a 2022 interview that he writes his in-world histories as deliberately unreliable "fake history" (a device he described for Fire and Blood by name, and which TWOIAF deploys identically).

Second, the canon splits the stone into two distinct mysteries that fans often blur. The carved oily stone (Seastone Chair, Toad Stone, Yeen, Asshai) has a greasy texture and repels or corrupts life. The fused black stone (Battle Isle fortress, Five Forts) is seamless, chisel-markless work resembling Valyrian dragonflame construction, but predates Valyria and lacks its ornamental style. Any complete theory has to explain both, and no single theory cleanly does.

Third, the Lovecraft DNA is confirmed at the level of names, not just vibes. TWOIAF uses Lovecraft's own terms "Deep Ones" and "Church of Starry Wisdom" (the latter from "The Haunter of the Dark," which Martin has identified as the first Lovecraft story he ever read: "I had never read a story that scared me more"). Leng, K'Dath, Sarnath, and Carcosa are verbatim weird-fiction toponyms. Martin wrote roughly 95 percent of TWOIAF's far-east material himself, per his co-authors, so none of this is co-author embroidery.

Fourth, Martin has never explained any of it, and the people closest to him hedge. Twenty-plus years of So Spake Martin entries show consistent stonewalling on Asshai ("Keep reading"). Co-authors Elio and Linda called the Lovecraft references "largely just paying homage," then in the same session said they "suspect" the no-children-in-Asshai detail "relates to the oily black stone" and offered their belief that the Seastone Chair was made by "some lost people from beyond the Sunset Sea... probably very connected to the oily black stone builders."

Fifth, among fan theories, the Deep Ones reading has the strongest textual base (it originates inside canon, via Maester Theron's Strange Stone), while LmL's moon-meteor framework is the most developed rival system. The two are compatible and often merged. The most defensible overall reading is given in the closing synthesis: a deep-past cataclysm story Martin seeded for texture and thematic depth, anchored to the Bloodstone Emperor and the Long Night, with the Deep Ones as its drowned residue, and with Euron Greyjoy as the plot vehicle through which any of it will surface in The Winds of Winter.

Confidence in the overall picture is high on the canon inventory and the Lovecraft sourcing, medium on theory evaluation, and necessarily speculative on forward-looking implications. One

research lane limitation: several major fan resources (A Wiki of Ice and Fire, westeros.org forums, Reddit) were bot-blocked during this run, so quotes were verified directly against a full-text index of the books instead, which is stronger sourcing for canon but thinner coverage of fandom traction.

1. Background

Scattered across Martin's world are ruins and artifacts of unusual black stone, ancient beyond record, attributed to no known people. A subset of these are described with a specific, repeated sensory signature: the stone is oily or greasy to the touch, and at Asshai it "seems to drink the light." The mystery has three layers: what the stone is, who built with it, and why Martin planted it. This report inventories every canon appearance, maps the surrounding lore, documents what Martin has actually said, grades the leading theories, and projects what each would mean for The Winds of Winter.

2. Canon Inventory

Every quote below was verified verbatim against a full-text search index of the published books (asearchoficeandfire.com). Chapter names follow that index.

2a. The carved oily stone (the true mystery)

The Seastone Chair, Old Wyk / Pyke. CANON. "Lord Balon occupied the Seastone Chair, carved in the shape of a great kraken from an immense block of oily black stone. Legend said that the First Men had found it standing on the shore of Old Wyk when they came to the Iron Islands" (A Clash of Kings, Theon II). This is the only occurrence of the phrase "oily black stone" in the five novels. In A Feast for Crows, Aeron Damphair treats the chair purely religiously ("No godless man may sit the Seastone Chair"); across all 57 corpus mentions, no other passage re-describes its material. SEMI-CANON adds Archmaester Haereg's theory that the ironborn descend from a people west of the Sunset Sea, which Yandel calls "the purest speculation."

Asshai-by-the-Shadow. SEMI-CANON. "Travelers tell us that the city is built entirely of black stone... Some say as well that the stone of Asshai has a greasy, unpleasant feel to it, that it seems to drink the light, dimming tapers and torches and hearth fires alike" (TWOIAF, Asshai-by-the-Shadow). Note the double hearsay: "travelers tell us," "some say."

Yeen, Sothoryos. SEMI-CANON. "A ruin older than time, built of oily black stone, in massive blocks so heavy that it would require a dozen elephants to move them... the jungle that surrounds it on every side has scarce touched it... Every attempt to rebuild or resettle Yeen has ended in horror" (TWOIAF, Sothoryos). Nymeria's Rhoynar colony there vanished overnight.

The Toad Stone, Isle of Toads. SEMI-CANON. "An ancient idol, a greasy black stone crudely carved into the semblance of a gigantic toad of malignant aspect, some forty feet high. The people of this isle... there is an unpleasant fishlike aspect to their faces, and many have webbed

hands and feet. If so, they are the sole surviving remnant of this forgotten race" (TWOIAF, The Basilisk Isles). The only canon use of the phrase "greasy black stone."

Marginal site: Xandarro Xhore's fort, Ax Isle. SEMI-CANON. The Qartheen corsair built "a grim black fort" from "the stones he found on Ax Isle" (TWOIAF, The Basilisk Isles). The text never calls these stones oily; fan catalogs include the site, but strictly it is unlabeled salvage.

2b. The fused black stone (a related but distinct mystery)

The Battle Isle fortress, Oldtown. SEMI-CANON. "The great square fortress of black stone that dominates that isle... predates the upper levels of the tower by thousands of years... its massive walls and labyrinthine interiors are all of solid rock, with no hint of joins or mortar, no chisel marks of any kind, a type of construction that is seen elsewhere, most notably in the dragonroads of the Freehold of Valyria, and the Black Walls that protect the heart of Old Volantis. But... the plain, unadorned style of architecture does not [suggest Valyria]... it too is singularly un-Valyrian" (TWOIAF, Oldtown). Even the name Battle Isle is a fossil: "known even in our oldest records, but why? What battle was fought there?... Even the singers are largely silent."

The Five Forts, Yi Ti. SEMI-CANON. "The great walls are single slabs of fused black stone... but this seems unlikely, for the Forts predate the Freehold's rise, and there is no record of any dragonlords ever coming so far east... their massive walls stand almost a thousand feet high... They still stand today, unmarked by time" (TWOIAF, Yi Ti). Important: the Five Forts are fused, never described as oily or greasy.

Baseline for comparison, Valyrian fused stone. CANON. The technique is documented and explained in-world: "The dragonlords of Valyria... possessed the art of turning stone to liquid with dragonflame, shaping it as they would, then fusing it harder than iron, steel, or granite" (TWOIAF, Oldtown, presented as common knowledge). POV-attested examples: the Valyrian roads ("a ribbon of fused stone," A Dance with Dragons, Tyrion II), the Long Bridge of Volantis (Tyrion VII), and the Black Wall of Volantis, "a great oval of fused stone two hundred feet high" (The Merchant's Man). Dragonstone castle shows the Valyrian aesthetic signature: dragon-shaped towers and "a thousand gargoyles," with stone-shaping arts "since lost to us" (A Clash of Kings, Prologue). The discriminator TWOIAF itself supplies: Valyrians decorated exuberantly; the mystery fortresses are plain.

2c. Ordinary black stone (the control group)

CANON. Moat Cailin is quarried black basalt, "blocks... so large it must once have taken a hundred men to hoist them into place" (A Dance with Dragons, Reek II): built, not fused. Pyke castle is "quarried from the same grey-black stone" as its cliffs (A Clash of Kings, Theon I), distinct from the Chair it houses. Blackhaven, the Breakwater bridge on Sisterton, and pre-melting Harrenhal are likewise mundane. Conflating these with the mystery stone is a category error the text does not make.

2d. Negative findings

The Lorath mazemakers built with "blocks of hewn stone" (TWOIAF, Lorath): hewn means chiseled, the opposite of the seamless fused work, and no color or texture is ever given. Leng's sealed underground cities of the Old Ones and the vanished forest-folk Ifequevron have no stone description at all. These belong to the same "vanished elder races" pattern but cannot be cited as black-stone sites. No numeric age estimate for the Battle Isle fortress exists anywhere in the primary text.

2e. The narrator-reliability structure

This is the inventory's most important finding. Only the Seastone Chair is attested in the novels proper. Everything else runs through Yandel, who hedges every claim and twice editorializes against black-stone theorizing: dismissing Haereg on the ironborn, and dismissing Maester Theron's Strange Stone with "his thesis has no factual basis and may safely be dismissed. And thus we find ourselves back whence we began, forced to concede that the beginnings of Oldtown, Battle Isle, and its fortress must forever remain a mystery to us." Meanwhile the Valyrian fused stone, the explained technology, is richly attested by POV characters. Martin put the mystery stone almost entirely behind an unreliable narrator, and he has confirmed the device is deliberate craft (Section 4).

3. The Associated Lore Map

Each mystery site comes wrapped in legend. Mapping which legends attach where:

Iron Islands cluster. The Grey King reigned "a thousand years and seven," wed a mermaid, slew the sea dragon Nagga and warmed his hall with "Nagga's living fire" until the Storm God drowned it, and his bones (per legend) became the stone ribs on Old Wyk. SEMI-CANON legend attached to the Seastone Chair site. Maester Theron's Strange Stone (SEMI-CANON, doubly filtered) supplies the in-world Deep Ones: "a queer, misshapen race of half men sired by creatures of the salt seas upon human women... the seed from which our legends of merlings have grown... whilst their terrible fathers are the truth behind the Drowned God of the ironborn."

Westerosi coastal folklore. CANON. Squishers at Crackclaw Point: fish-headed, webbed-handed creatures who keep "girls to breed with and boys to eat" (A Feast for Crows, Brienne IV, told by Nimble Dick Crabb). The Sistermen of the Three Sisters have webbed hands (A Dance with Dragons, Davos I). Patchface drowned in Shipbreaker Bay, washed ashore days later broken in body and mind, and now produces "under the sea" sayings; Melisandre flags him: "Melisandre's face darkened. 'That creature is dangerous. Many a time I have glimpsed him in my flames. Sometimes there are skulls about him, and his lips are red with blood'" (A Dance with Dragons, Jon X; verified verbatim during the fact-check pass). The exact duration of his drowning is not clearly stated in the text; fan claims of "two days dead" could not be verified.

Far-east cluster. SEMI-CANON. The Bloodstone Emperor usurped the Amethyst Empress (the Blood Betrayal), "practiced dark arts, torture, and necromancy... and cast down the true gods to worship a black stone that had fallen from the sky," and "many scholars count [him] the first High Priest of the sinister Church of Starry Wisdom, which persists to this day in many port cities." In Yi Ti's annals the Blood Betrayal "ushered in the age of darkness called the Long Night" (TWOIAF, Yi Ti). This is the only black stone in canon with a celestial origin claim, and note the text never says the sky-stone was oily; equating the two is FAN THEORY, though a natural one.

Asshai anomalies. SEMI-CANON. City large enough to hold Volantis, Qarth, King's Landing, and Oldtown together, population of a market town; one building in ten lit by night; no children; no animals larger than rats (beasts brought by ship soon die, an account attributed to Archmaester Marwyn); the black glistening waters of the Ash; ghost grass; the corpse city Stygai upriver that even shadowbinders fear.

Lorath. SEMI-CANON. The mazemakers, "massively built and larger than men," vanished "long before the dawn of true history," destroyed per Lorathi legend by "an enemy from the sea: merlings in some versions of the tale, selkies and walrus-men in others." The only textual bridge to the black stone is Archmaester Quillion's speculation that the Battle Isle labyrinth was mazemaker work.

The pattern fans assemble from this map: a global network of pre-human coastal builders, a war or cataclysm involving the sea, a sky-fallen stone tied to the Long Night, and living residue (squishers, Sistermen, Toad Isle islanders, Patchface) in the present story. The pattern is real; the connections between its nodes are almost entirely inference.

4. What Martin Has Actually Said

4a. Confirmed authorial statements (all with citations)

On Lovecraft, extensively. In "A Horrifying Announcement" (Not a Blog, April 26, 2017, announcing the Miskatonic Scholarship he personally funds for cosmic-horror writers): "I fell in love with monsters and scary stories... thanks to a gentleman out of Providence who had died before I was born," and "No werewolf, no vampire, no thing going bump in the night could give me chills to equal those provided by the cosmic horrors that Lovecraft evoked." Crucially: "I had never heard of HPL until I read 'The Haunter of the Dark'... I had never read a story that scared me more." That story is the source of the Church of Starry Wisdom name. Martin has never publicly connected the two names himself; the homage inference is ours, but it is about as safe as inference gets.

On unreliable in-world history as deliberate craft. History of Westeros interview, August 2022: "I was playing with the history, with actual history, and writing this as a fake history book... it is a pseudo history of sorts, by an in world character." His stated model was real historiography's

inconsistency. The quotes concern Fire and Blood; no direct quote extends the point to TWOIAF specifically, but TWOIAF uses the identical device.

On Asshai: twenty years of stonewalling. "Keep reading" (So Spake Martin, 2002, on what the Shadow Lands are); "there always need to be mysteries beyond the hill"; chances of seeing Asshai: "Very remote" (SSM, 2003); "Only in flashback and memory, if at all" (Asshai.com chat, 2008).

On the Drowned God. "Yes, it's an ironborn thing" (SSM, 1999, on whether the faith is a unique ironborn invention); asked in 2008 whether the drowned men are truly drowned: "no." He has said nothing about whether a real entity stands behind the god, and the 1999 answer predates the Deep Ones material by fifteen years.

In his own earlier fiction. "The Stone City" (1977) centers on a vast abandoned pre-human stone city whose Builders are never found; Martin described the story as mixing "elements of Lovecraft and Kafka" (commentary sourced via Goodreads' reproduction rather than a print edition). In Dreamsongs (2003) he pays tribute to At the Mountains of Madness as a model for science fiction "invigorated by the lurking menace of horror" (as recorded in Strange Horizons' review; the printed commentary was not directly verified this run).

4b. Semi-authorial statements (Elio Garcia and Linda Antonsson, 2015 Reddit AMA)

Asked whether the TWOIAF Lovecraft references have a deeper purpose: "As with the dead cities of oily black stone, it's all awfully creepy, isn't it? But yes, it's largely just paying homage." Note the load-bearing word "largely."

Asked about "there are no children in Asshai": "It's creepy, that's the main thing we take out of it! But we suspect it relates to the oily black stone. Will we ever learn more? ...only the Shadow knows."

Asked who built the Seastone Chair: "Some lost people from beyond the Sunset Sea, who are probably very connected to the oily black stone builders."

And the provenance fact that upgrades all the eastern lore: "95% of the far east material was written by George... 90% of what he wrote is what actually made it into the book." The Bloodstone Emperor, the Great Empire of the Dawn, and Asshai's anomalies are Martin's own pen.

4c. Negative findings (important for hygiene)

No SSM entry, interview, blog post, or con report contains a Martin statement explaining, or even substantively discussing, the oily black stone, the Battle Isle fortress, the Deep Ones, the Grey King, the Bloodstone Emperor, or the Great Empire of the Dawn. The AWOIAF wiki's own citation practice confirms it: every black-stone claim cites TWOIAF chapters only. The oft-cited 2005 Nottingham "Lovecraftiness of A Feast for Crows" moment is a fan's anecdote of a friendly

exchange, with no quotable Martin statement. Martin does not appear in the 2008 documentary Lovecraft: Fear of the Unknown, and no standalone Martin-authored Lovecraft appreciation essay could be located. No sourceable Martin statement on Patchface's significance was found either, despite wide circulation of such claims.

5. The Literary DNA

Verified borrowings, strongest first. All are FAN-OBSERVED but rest on verifiable primary texts on both sides.

Named lifts (effectively certain). "Deep Ones" is Lovecraft's own term for the fish-frog sea race of "The Shadow Over Innsmouth" (1936), used with the same hybrid-interbreeding premise. "Church of Starry Wisdom" is the cult of "The Haunter of the Dark" (1936), the first Lovecraft story Martin read; in both worlds it is a star-cult tied to a sinister stone (Lovecraft's Shining Trapezohedron, "fashioned on dark Yuggoth," also came from the sky). Leng, K'Dath, and Sarnath are Lovecraft toponyms placed on Martin's maps; Leng even comes with worshipped "Old Ones" in sealed underground ruins. Carcosa, with its exiled sixty-ninth Yellow Emperor, imports Robert W. Chambers' The King in Yellow (by way of Ambrose Bierce).

Structural borrowings (strong). The Innsmouth look reproduced twice: the Toad Isle islanders (fishlike faces, webbed extremities, around a greasy black idol) and the squishers of Crackclaw Point. Sunken and cyclopean pre-human cities ("The Call of Cthulhu"'s R'lyeh, At the Mountains of Madness) as the template for Yeen, Asshai, and the megastructures. The ironborn liturgy "What is dead may never die, but rises again, harder and stronger" echoing "That is not dead which can eternal lie, / And with strange aeons even death may die," plus an ironborn lord literally named Dagon Greyjoy.

Caveats that keep us honest. Lovecraft's alien masonry is greenish-black or slaty; the "oily/greasy" texture is Martin's own contribution (Robert E. Howard's 1931 story "The Black Stone" was flagged as a possible antecedent but could not be verified this run). "The Stone City"'s alien metropolis is gray with obsidian towers; the inheritance is conceptual, not verbal. Clark Ashton Smith's Zothique plausibly stands behind Asshai's dying-sorcerous-east aesthetic, but no documented link exists. No peer-reviewed scholarship on Lovecraftian elements in ASOIAF was found; the most serious critical treatments are Sean T. Collins' 2014 Deep Ones essay and Tyler Dean's Tor.com/Reactor horror essays (Dean holds a PhD and lectures on Gothic literature, making his the closest thing to scholarly treatment).

6. Theory Evaluation

Theory 1: A pre-human aquatic race (the Deep Ones) built the oily stone structures

Strongest support: it is the only theory stated inside canon (Maester Theron's Strange Stone links the Seastone Chair and Battle Isle stone and names the builders); the Lovecraft names are deliberate; the living-residue pattern (Toad Isle islanders, squishers, Sistermen, mazemaker-killing merlings) spans both continents; the "enemy from the sea" destroyed the mazemakers in Lorathi legend; Patchface exists and Melisandre fears him. Strongest counters: Yandel dismisses Theron flatly (though that may be the point of the device); the fused stone (Battle Isle, Five Forts) requires heat technology hard to square with an underwater race; Elio and Linda point to human builders "from beyond the Sunset Sea" instead; nothing in the five novels requires nonhuman builders. Traction: widest in the fandom. Verdict: FAN THEORY, medium-high confidence that some aquatic elder-race element is real in the deep lore; low confidence in any specific version.

Theory 2: The Bloodstone Emperor's sky-fallen stone (meteor origin), including LmL's Mythical Astronomy

Strongest support: the only celestial origin claim in canon; explicit link to the Long Night and (via "many scholars") the Church of Starry Wisdom; the Church parallels Lovecraft's sky-stone cult precisely; bloodstone-as-black-stone wordplay; LmL's system additionally catches the match between Dany's ghost-kings dream (eyes of opal, amethyst, tourmaline, jade) and the gemstone emperors of the Great Empire of the Dawn. Strongest counters: canon never says the fallen stone was oily, never places it anywhere on the map afterward, and the entire account is Yi Tish legend at two removes; the moon-meteor mechanism is pure superstructure. Traction: the most developed single-author framework (essay series plus History of Westeros platform). Verdict: FAN THEORY, medium confidence in the minimal claim (the sky-stone and the Long Night are connected and Martin planted the Lovecraft cult around it deliberately); low confidence in the full astronomical apparatus.

Theory 3: Lost human civilization with dragon-adjacent technology (Great Empire of the Dawn as builders)

Strongest support: the fused stone matches known dragonflame technique; the Five Forts predate Valyria, implying earlier dragon-wielders in the far east; Asshai as a depopulated imperial capital explains its absurd size; Elio and Linda's Sunset Sea "lost people" comment gestures at human builders; LmL argues you would not build a thriving metropolis from cursed material, so Asshai's stone was more plausibly blackened later by cataclysm. Strongest counters: explains the fused stone well but the carved oily stone poorly (why would human dragonlords carve a kraken throne and a toad idol in a texture that repels life?); wholly dependent on semi-canon. Traction: strong as the standard companion to Theory 2. Verdict: FAN THEORY, medium confidence for the fused-stone sites specifically; weak for the oily carved sites.

Theory 4: Corrupted or organic stone (burnt weirwood, "the stone is alive," etc.)

Essentially no independent essay corpus exists; the idea survives mainly as a motif inside LmL's framework. The strongest thing it explains is the texture itself (greasy, light-drinking, life-repelling reads more like substance than architecture). Verdict: FAN THEORY, low confidence, underdeveloped.

The synthesis position most of the serious fandom converges on

The two leading theories are compatible: a sky-fallen stone worshipped by the Bloodstone Emperor's cult (Theory 2) and a race or cult of Deep Ones associated with the drowned side of the mystery (Theory 1), with human empires (Theory 3) responsible for the fused megastructures. Fans increasingly treat "who built with the oily stone" and "what the oily stone is" as separate questions, which is exactly the split the canon's carved-versus-fused distinction invites.

7. Points of Contradiction

In-world contradiction, by design. Yandel's editorial dismissals versus the pattern he faithfully records. The maester dismisses Theron and Haereg, yet Martin (who wrote 95 percent of the eastern material and confirmed the fake-history device) chose to put the Deep Ones passage, the fishlike islanders, and the greasy stone into his mouth anyway. The unreliable narrator cuts both ways and is the mystery's protective shell.

Homage versus mystery. Elio and Linda's "largely just paying homage" sits in tension with their own suspicion about Asshai's children and their Sunset Sea builders belief, offered in the same AMA. Resolution: the Lovecraft names are homage; the black stone network they decorate appears to be a live, protected mystery. The hedge word "largely" is doing real work.

Human versus nonhuman builders. LmL (Great Empire of the Dawn) versus the Deep Ones camp. Both sides read the same passages. The carved/fused split lets both be partially right, and the evidence currently supports exactly that division of labor.

Cross-agent factual corrections made during this run: the squishers tale is in A Feast for Crows, Brienne IV (one agent had Brienne VI); TWOIAF does connect the Bloodstone Emperor to the Church of Starry Wisdom, though only as what "many scholars count" (one agent overstated the absence of the link); the Ax Isle fort is "grim black," never oily (fan catalogs overclaim it); Patchface's exact drowning duration is not in the text (fan shorthand "dead two days" is unverified).

8. Single-Source Claims

Flagged for extra scrutiny, per methodology:

The Elio/Linda AMA cluster (homage quote, Asshai suspicion, Sunset Sea builders, the 95 percent figure) all trace to one 2015 Reddit session. It is verbatim-archived and in character with their public statements, but it is one source, semi-authorial, and a decade old.

The "GRRM wrote 95% of the far east" figure has no independent confirmation beyond that AMA (the AWOIAF wiki cites the same AMA).

"The Stone City" commentary ("elements of Lovecraft and Kafka") was sourced through Goodreads' reproduction of Martin's commentary rather than a print edition.

The claim that no peer-reviewed scholarship exists rests on one research pass; a dedicated Project MUSE / academic-database sweep remains undone.

The Robert E. Howard "Black Stone" antecedent is flagged, not established.

9. Forward-Looking Implications (The Winds of Winter and the endgame)

Euron Greyjoy is the delivery mechanism. Whatever Martin intends to pay off, Euron is the only POV-adjacent character actively touching the mystery's levers: he sits the Seastone Chair, he has been to Valyria (he claims), his TWOW sample chapter ("The Forsaken," read publicly by Martin at Balticon 2016; widely documented but outside this run's verified evidence base) shows him in full cosmic-horror register, sacrificing holy men to the sea and dreaming of godhood. If the Deep Ones or the Drowned God's reality are ever confirmed, it will almost certainly be through Euron's arc. The 2002 SSM confirming "Euron is not a faceless man" is the only direct Martin comment on him retrieved in this research pass, which itself suggests protection.

Oldtown and the Citadel. Sam's arc places a POV character on top of the Battle Isle fortress for the first time. If Theory 1 or 2 surfaces in the main series, the Hightower's base, the Citadel's suppressed lore (Marwyn: "the grey sheep"), and a possible Euron strike at Oldtown (heavily foreshadowed at the end of A Feast for Crows) are the stage. A confirmed Deep Ones reveal would recontextualize the Hightower's "gloomy halls, vaults, and chambers of the strange stone below" (TWOIAF, Oldtown; semi-canon).

The Iron Islands plotline. Theory 1 predicts the Drowned God material is not just religion: Patchface near Shireen (and Melisandre's fear of him), Aeron's visions in "The Forsaken," and Damphair's drowned-man revival all become foreshadowing rather than color. Theory 2/3 predicts the payoff stays mythic-historical: background revelation (perhaps via Melisandre's or Bran's flashbacks) rather than sea monsters onstage.

Asshai. Martin's own statements cap expectations: "only in flashback and memory, if at all." Any Asshai payoff will come secondhand, most plausibly through Melisandre's POV memories.

Honest base rate: Martin has kept this mystery sealed for almost thirty years and explicitly values "mysteries beyond the hill." The likeliest outcome is partial, ambiguous payoff through Euron and Oldtown, with the deep history never fully explained on the page.

10. Synthesis: The Most Defensible Reading

Stripped to what the evidence actually supports:

The oily black stone is a deliberately Lovecraftian deep-history layer that Martin built into his world from at least A Clash of Kings (the Seastone Chair, 1998) and expanded enormously in the far-east sections of TWOIAF (2014), which he personally wrote. The borrowed names (Deep Ones, Church of Starry Wisdom, Leng, K'Dath, Carcosa) are confirmed homage; Martin's lifelong, documented devotion to Lovecraft makes the mode unmistakable. But homage explains the decoration, not the architecture. Martin placed the entire network behind his unreliable maester-narrator, has stonewalled every direct question for twenty years, and his co-authors, while waving fans off with "largely just homage," privately suspect the no-children detail of Asshai connects to the stone and believe in a single connected builder culture. That is not how anyone treats mere set dressing.

The canon's own structure suggests the intended shape of the answer. The text splits the stone in two: fused megastructures that look like dragonflame work predating Valyria (best explained by a lost human civilization in the Great Empire of the Dawn mold), and carved greasy stone with a consistent signature (light-drinking, life-repelling, coastal, associated with fishlike peoples and drowned gods) that resists any human-technology explanation and everywhere points seaward. The one celestial data point, the Bloodstone Emperor's sky-fallen black stone, is welded by the text itself to the Long Night and to a star-worshipping cult Martin named after Lovecraft's. The most economical reading that honors all of it: in the deep past of Martin's world there was a cataclysm associated with something that fell from the sky and something that came from the sea; the Long Night, the Drowned God, the greasy stone, and the world's scattered fishlike peoples are its surviving debris; and the ironborn, whose priest-king Euron now sits a Deep One artifact while dreaming of apocalypse, are where the debris becomes plot.

Confidence: high that the mystery is real, connected, and protected; medium that the carved/fused split marks two different origins as sketched above; low on any mechanism (meteors, moon-fall, literal Deep One cities). And a permanent caveat, in Yandel's own words, that Martin may intend to keep it this way: "forced to concede that the beginnings of Oldtown, Battle Isle, and its fortress must forever remain a mystery to us."

11. Source Reliability Matrix

51 unique sources across four research lanes, sorted by aggregate reliability score (source-type weight x agent confidence x URL status + corroboration bonus). Summary: 19 high, 11 medium, 21 low. The low tier is dominated by fan-theory essays, which the formula deliberately discounts as sources of fact even when they are excellent documentation of the theories themselves. URL status: 20 live, 6 bot-blocked but presumed valid, 4 unreachable from the research network, all retained with caveats.

Source	Yea	Title	Category	Age	URL	Scor	Tier	Cited by

	r			nt conf.		e		
GRRM	1998	A Clash of Kings (Theon I/II, Prologue)	Primary canon	High	Live	1.0	High	canon
GRRM	2005	A Feast for Crows (Prophet, Drowned Man, Brienne IV)	Primary canon	High	Live	1.0	High	canon,fandom,influence
GRRM	2011	A Dance with Dragons (Tyrion II/VII, Merchant's Man, Davos I, Reek II)	Primary canon	High	Live	1.0	High	canon,fandom
GRRM	1996	A Game of Thrones (Catelyn VIII); A Storm of Swords (Davos II)	Primary canon	High	Live	1.0	High	canon
mrdziuban	2026	asearchoficeandfire.com full-text index (verification tool)	Tool/primary	High	Live	1.0	High	canon,synthesis
GRRM	2017	A Horrifying Announcement (Not a Blog)	Authorial primary	High	Live	1.0	High	author
Lovecraft, H.P.	1936	The Haunter of the Dark (full primary text)	Literary primary	High	Live	1.0	High	influence
Fattest Leech of Ice and Fire	2019	The Stone City (1977) transcribed	Primary transcription	High	Live	1.0	High	influence
Martin/Garcia/Antonsson	2014	The World of Ice and Fire (10 sections)	Semi-canon	Med	Live	0.9	High	canon,fandom,influence
Dean, Tyler / Reactor (Tor.com)	2019	ASOIAF Is a Horror Story That's Been Lost in Translation	Criticism	High	Live	0.9	High	fandom,influence
GRRM via Westeros.org	1999	SSM: The Drowned God and More	Authorial primary	High	Blocked	0.8	High	author
GRRM via Westeros.org	2002	SSM: Eastern Cities and Peoples	Authorial primary	High	Blocked	0.8	High	author
GRRM via Westeros.org	2003	SSM: Seeing Asshai	Authorial primary	High	Blocked	0.8	High	author
GRRM via Westeros.org	2008	SSM: Asshai.com Forum Chat	Authorial primary	High	Blocked	0.8	High	author
GRRM via Westeros.org	2002	SSM: Euron and the Globe	Authorial primary	High	Blocked	0.8	High	author
The Sudden Storm	2019	All the Black Stone of ASoIaF	Fan essay	High	Live	0.8	Medium	fandom,influence
Winter Is Coming	2020	GRRM is looking for a cosmic horror writer to sponsor	Journalism	High	Live	0.8	High	influence
Goodreads	2009	The Stone City (with GRRM commentary)	Aggregator	High	Live	0.8	High	influence
Wikipedia	2026	The King in Yellow	Encyclopedia	High	Live	0.8	High	influence
Wikipedia	2026	Deep One	Encyclopedia	High	Live	0.8	High	influence
AWOIAF	2026	Black stone (as citation index)	Wiki	High	Blocked	0.74	Medium	author,fandom
AWOIAF	202	Deep Ones	Wiki	High	Blocke	0.74	Mediu	fandom,influence

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AWOIAF	2026	Church of Starry Wisdom	Wiki	High	Blocked	0.74	Medium	fandom,influence
Harvey, Colin / Strange Horizons	2007	Dreamsongs: A GRRM Retrospective (review)	Journalism	Med	Live	0.66	Medium	author,influence
AWOIAF	2026	Strange Stone	Wiki	High	Blocked	0.64	Medium	fandom
AWOIAF	2026	Asshai	Wiki	High	Blocked	0.64	Medium	fandom
AWOIAF	2026	Mazemakers	Wiki	High	Blocked	0.64	Medium	fandom
AWOIAF	2026	Squishers	Wiki	High	Blocked	0.64	Medium	influence
LmL	2016	The Bloodstone Emperor Azor Ahai	Fan essay	Med	Live	0.59	Medium	fandom,influence
Uproxx/HitFix	2016	Game of Thrones Has Lovecraft Influence Hidden in Its Dark Fantasy	Journalism	Med	Live	0.56	Medium	influence
LmL	2016	The Grey King and the Sea Dragon	Fan essay	Med	Live	0.49	Low	fandom
LmL	2020	Great Empire of the Dawn: Dragonlords of Ancient Asshai	Fan essay	Med	Live	0.49	Low	fandom
The Maidenvault	2018	Oily Black Stone and Merlings, Part I: Sea Dragons	Fan essay	Med	Live	0.49	Low	influence
Company of the Cat	2023	Squishers & Deep Ones (video/podcast)	Podcast	Med	Live	0.49	Low	fandom
Historical Analysis of ASOIAF	2018	Yandel Further Speculates On Battle Isle & The Deep Ones	Fan essay	Med	Live	0.49	Low	fandom
Garcia & Antonsson	2015	r/asoiaf AMAA (top 20 questions)	Semi-authorial	Med	Blocked	0.45	Low	author
Westeros.org	2005	SSM: UK Signing Tour, Nottingham (fan report)	Con report	Med	Blocked	0.45	Low	author
Westeros.org	2008	SSM: Biblioteca de Telheiras, Lisbon (fan report)	Con report	Med	Blocked	0.45	Low	author
Forum of Ice and Fire	2020	Fish Men theory thread	Forum	Med	Blocked	0.39	Low	fandom
Ice and Fire Wiki (fandom.com)	2026	Tributes and homages	Wiki	Med	Blocked	0.39	Low	influence
TV Tropes	2026	The World of Ice & Fire	Wiki	Med	Blocked	0.39	Low	influence
Thousand Worlds Wiki	2026	In the House of the Worm	Wiki	Med	Blocked	0.39	Low	influence
Wikipedia	2026	Zothique (collection)	Encyclopedia	Low	Live	0.32	Low	influence
History of Westeros	2022	GRRM in Conversation (interview)	Interview	High	Unreach.	0.3	Low	author
The Sudden Storm	2018	The Truth Behind the Drowned God and the Deep Ones	Fan essay	Low	Live	0.28	Low	fandom
The Maidenvault	201	Oily Black Stone	Fan essay	Low	Live	0.28	Low	fandom

	8	and Merlings, Part II: Seastone						
AWOIAF	2026	Oily black stone	Wiki	Low	Blocked	0.26	Low	canon
Collins, Sean T.	2014	What We Talk About When We Talk About the Deep Ones	Criticism	High	Unreach.	0.24	Low	influence
History of Westeros	2019	Asshai-by-the-Shadow (podcast, with LmL)	Podcast	Med	Unreach.	0.17	Low	fandom
History of Westeros	2017	The Prophecies of Patchface (podcast)	Podcast	Med	Unreach.	0.17	Low	fandom
godsofterror	2018	The Long Night and Starry Wisdom	Fan essay	Low	Unreach.	0.08	Low	influence

12. Research Methodology Note

Four parallel research lanes: primary canon (all quotes verified verbatim against a full-text index of the books), authorial statements (SSM archive, Not a Blog, interviews, verified against archived captures), fan analysis corpus (essay sites, forums, podcasts), and literary influences (Lovecraft primary texts verified at hplovecraft.com). Cross-referencing produced 20 major claims, 4 factual corrections between lanes, and 5 flagged single-source claims. Major access limitations: A Wiki of Ice and Fire, westeros.org forums, Reddit, and Tumblr were bot-blocked or unreachable during the run.

Appendix A. Claim Cross-Reference Matrix

Y = lane supports the claim; - = lane did not address it. Lanes: Canon = primary canon texts; Author = GRRM statements and SSM; Fandom = fan analysis corpus; Influence = literary influences and criticism.

Claim	Canon	Author	Fandom	Influence	Agreement
Seastone Chair is oily black stone; pre-First Men legend	Y	Y	Y	Y	Full agreement
“Oily black stone” appears only once in the five novels	Y	-	-	-	Single-lane, exhaustively verified
Battle Isle fortress: fused, seamless, un-Valyrian	Y	-	Y	Y	Agreement among reporting lanes
Theron's Strange Stone names the Deep Ones in-world	Y	-	Y	Y	Agreement among reporting lanes
Asshai stone is greasy, drinks light; no children in Asshai	Y	Y	Y	Y	Full agreement
Yeen: oily black ruin; every resettlement ends in horror	Y	-	Y	Y	Agreement among reporting lanes
Toad Stone idol plus fishlike islanders	Y	-	Y	Y	Agreement among reporting lanes
Bloodstone Emperor: sky-fallen stone, Starry Wisdom, Long Night	Y	-	Y	Y	Agreement after cross-lane correction
Church of Starry Wisdom / Deep Ones are Lovecraft name-lifts	Y	Y	Y	Y	Full agreement
GRRM has never explained the black stone (negative finding)	-	Y	-	Y	Independently corroborated twice
Elio/Linda: “largely homage” hedge; Sunset Sea builders belief	-	Y	-	-	Single source (2015 AMA)
GRRM wrote ~95% of TWOIAF far-east material	-	Y	-	-	Single source (2015 AMA)
Five Forts: fused not oily; predate Valyria	Y	-	Y	-	Agreement among reporting lanes
Fused stone = dragonflame technique (pre-Valyrian extension is inference)	Y	-	Y	-	Partial; extension is fan inference
Mazemakers built in hewn stone; destroyed by sea creatures (legend)	Y	-	Y	-	Agreement among reporting lanes
Squishers / Sistermen reproduce the Innsmouth pattern	Y	-	Y	Y	Agreement among reporting lanes
LmL moon-meteor framework	-	-	Y	-	Single lane; graded as theory
Preston Jacobs has no dedicated treatment (negative finding)	-	-	Y	-	Single lane
The Stone City (1977) as Lovecraft/Kafka ancestor, per GRRM	-	-	-	Y	Single lane; primary text verified
Patchface drowned and revived; Melisandre fears him (ADWD Jon X)	Y	-	Y	-	Verified verbatim in fact-check pass

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